

Should I tell my kids how much I earn?

Hell no!

Instead, respond with your own question: ‘Why do you ask?’

Maybe she has heard you complain about money, and she thinks you’re broke. Perhaps she’s comparing you to her friend’s father. Either way, you need to provide her with some context. Remember, your teen daughter is getting paid \$8.31 an hour flipping burgers at McDonald’s. That’s her frame of reference. She has no real understanding of how much it costs to live. If you are going to answer, give her the full picture of all your expenses!

How do I convince my kids that I don’t have an endless supply of money?

Instead of lying to your kids that you can’t afford something, just say: ‘I don’t want to spend my money on that.’

Having their own pocket money helps here: you can explain that their jam jars are like your bank accounts. They don’t have an endless supply of money and neither do you. If they really, truly want something, they can work hard, save up and buy it themselves.

I’m a single parent, and my ex undoes all my good work when the kids stay with them!

I am not qualified to answer this question. So I’m going to hand this over to my sister—a single mother of two wonderful boys—to answer:

‘My advice is to communicate and decide together how you will address these issues for your children. But if that doesn’t work, don’t ever fall into the trap of bad-mouthing your ex to your kids. Talk with your children about how “we” do things at “our” house and be consistent with that. One day they will realise that a Disneyland parent is not meeting their needs and will recognise that you have done the best you could for them.’